This is Why I'll Never be an Adult (From Hyperbole and a Half)

By Allie Brosh

INTRODUCTION

Grocery shopping ??? My parents' fridge is already stocked.
Paying the cell phone bill? I'm on my parents' plan.
Health insurance? Ditto – at least until I'm 26.
Growing up?? Optional because, for many of us, it is.

But there will come a time when you are suddenly an adult. You're definitely not ready for it and you feel like you barely got any warning, but there it is – you're an adult. Deal with it. Enter the "real world."

*It's called **Adulting**: (It's a real word – Adopted into the Dictionary officially in 2014. **Adulting**: the practice of behaving in a way characteristic of a responsible adult, especially the accomplishment of mundane but necessary tasks. In fact, Amazon has a multitude of "**ADULTING**" guides for our clueless generation, because guess what they don't teach you in school? **ADULTING**!*

This is Why I'll never be an Adult from Hyperbole and a Half by Allie Brosh

OR EDUCATIONAL

4NG Fanatics

NOTE: Text shown in red is not in the original text and has been added for transition/clarification purposes.

I have repeatedly discovered that it is important for me not to surpass my capacity for responsibility. Over the years, this capacity has grown, but the results of exceeding it have not changed.

Normally, my capacity is exceeded gradually, through the accumulation of simple, daily tasks.

My productivity is directly related to my level of responsibility.

- **Stage 1:** Taking care of only the very basics necessary to survival (eating, sleeping, breathing) – I'm doing pretty well! I can breathe and beat my heart like a champion!

But a few times a year, I spontaneously decide that I'm ready to be a *real* adult. I don't know why I decide this; it always ends terribly for me. But I do it anyway.

- **Stage 2:** A few very minor tasks, like grocery shopping and brushing my hair. – Look at me go! I'm actually getting stuff done!

I sit myself down and tell myself how I'm going to start cleaning the house every day and paying my bills on time and replying to emails before my inbox reaches quadruple digits. Schedules are drafted. Day-planners are purchased. I stock up on fancy food because I'm also planning on morphing into a master chef and actually cooking instead of just eating nachos for dinner every night. I prepare for my new life as an adult like some people prepare for the apocalypse.

- **Stage 3:** One major responsibility, like (feeding the dog) – I'M SUCCESSFUL!!!!!

The first day or two of my plans usually goes okay.

- Email!
- Go to the bank like an adult
- Grocery Shopping
- Clean all the things!

4NG Fanatics

For a little while, I actually feel grown-up and responsible. I strut around with my head held high, looking the other responsible people in the eye with that knowing glance that says "*I understand. I'm responsible now too. Just look at my groceries.*"

At some point, I start feeling self-congratulatory. This is a mistake.

I begin to feel like I've accomplished my goals. It's like I think that adulthood is something that can be earned like a trophy in one monumental burst of effort and then admired and coveted for the rest of one's life.

(Show trophy) That right there is my ability to be responsible. I won it when I was 25.

- **Stage 4:** Now there are a few more things – (paying bills, cleaning the kitchen and bathroom, going to the bank) – Wait . . . what is this? I have to go to the bank? What am I, some sort of wizard?

- **Stage 5:** Now even a few more – (renewing my driver's license, laundry, changing the oil in my

car) – I did three things yesterday! Now I'm supposed to keep doing things? It's like the things never end!

- **Stage 6:** One more . . . (April 15 – Taxes are due today! And I'm 26 – I have to find a job with health insurance) – SYSTEM FAILURE!

What usually ends up happening is that I completely wear myself out. Thinking that I've earned it, I give myself permission to slack off for a while and recover. Since I've exceeded my capacity for responsibility in such a dramatic fashion, I end up needing to take more recovery time than usual. This is when the guilt-spiral starts.

The longer I procrastinate on returning phone calls and emails, the more guilty I feel about it. The guilt I feel causes me to avoid the issue further, which only leads to more guilt and more procrastination. It gets to the point where I don't email someone for fear of reminding them that they emailed me and thus giving them a reason to be disappointed in me.

4NG Fanatics

Then the guilt from my ignored responsibilities grows so large that merely carrying it around with me feels like a huge responsibility. It takes up a sizable portion of my capacity, leaving me almost completely useless for anything other than consuming nachos and surfing the internet like an attention-deficient squirrel.

At some point in this endlessly spiraling disaster, I am forced to throw all of my energy into trying to be an adult again, just to dig myself out of the pit I've fallen into. The problem is that I enter this round of attempted adulthood already burnt out from the last round. I can't not fail. *(in an utterly defeated and small, sad voice)*

- email
- bank
- grocery shopping
- clean all the things?

It always ends the same way. Slumped and haggard, I contemplate the seemingly endless tasks ahead of me.

Work? . . . .

4NG Fanatics

And then I rebel. No . . . . *(re-energized)* INTERNET! .

. . Forever . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Allie Brosh
Book: Hyperbole and a Half
ISBN: 978-1451666175
Publisher: Touchstone Books
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2013

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY